perfect husband, the perfect father for children. Maybe we'd think of it as old-fashioned, but I think it's a good thing, how important family life is in that society. When they look at me, they see a good-looking bloke who'd make a good partner; he likes being at home, he loves his wife and he's good with the kids. That's why, when it comes to commercials and sponsorships, in the Far East, they like Victoria and I being together. There's an interest in my soccer and in Victoria's pop career, but those things on their own don't explain why we get the reaction we do in Japan. It's only being there and talking to people you get an idea of how we're seen out there; and we've realized it's very different to the way people see us back home. People in England know I'm a husband and a father but I think what I do for a living is more what drives it all.

I enjoy the Far East, even though it can get a bit overwhelming at times. As far as vacations go, if I have the choice and a couple of days available, it's a quick jaunt to the South of France. We'll often stay at Elton and David's house. And soon, once it's in shape, they'll be able to stay at ours: we bought a villa down there in 2002. With the family, though, I'll always be ready for a trip to the States. America is such a big country—and so hooked into other sports like basketball and American football—that I don't have the same kind of profile there as in other parts of the world. The press like to make out that I've got this dream about 'breaking' the US market. The real reason I like going to America is actually that I do sometimes daydream about what it would be like to live there. And that's not just because the Big Macs are so much better than they are in England. With not being so widely recognized in America, when I go out, I'm not in the position where I'm thinking about people looking at me. I can spend some time looking at them instead. And what I see is a passion for their own country that I really admire. The Stars and Stripes are everywhere. The way we get excited about England when it comes to big soccer tournaments is how Americans seem to feel about their country all year round. I get the impression that everybody there, whatever background they come from, feels like America is their country and they're proud of it. I think that makes a big difference to the way of life: people in the States seem to have a very positive attitude about themselves because of it.

We had a great time in America in the summer of 2003, even though we ended up staying in the middle of the desert just to get a bit of private family time to ourselves. Because of all the talk about a move to Real Madrid, I understood why there were so many journalists and photographers following us around in New York and Los Angeles. There were a couple of public appearances in the diary too: the MTV awards and a day training with the American women's national soccer team. I appreciate that you can't turn the